



states RAJASTHAN

POWER TO THE PEOPLE

To push reforms, Raje cuts off power supply to 1,000 villages, a huge gamble with state elections looming. It works, improving power supply and changing lives in rural Rajasthan.

■ By Rohit Parihar

Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje is a risk taker. She often rushes in where her political counterparts fear to tread. Power, for her, has a different meaning, and in this case, literally so. Facing Assembly elections in November this year, Raje took the gutsy but politically suicidal step of cutting off power to 1,000 villages in four districts of Bharatpur division, an area from where she has a strong support base. The reason: villagers were notorious for stealing electricity and refused to pay for it, even after the state started providing uninterrupted power. This was three months ago when Raje realised that she needed to take some hard decisions if her power reforms campaign was to work.

Bharatpur used to get a few hours of erratic power daily but even then two-thirds of the supply would be stolen. Officials would be threatened and even assaulted if they tried to enforce the law. Raje decided to provide uninterrupted power, hoping that the villagers would

EXERCISE OF POWER: (Top) Kamali Regar of village Hari Ram Pura who can now study at night; Raje (left)

